caustically, adding, ‘Just because they look and talk like NGOs doesn’t make them leaders, for God’s sake.’

This is perhaps where he should have taken a cue from M.S. Dhoni. As India captain, Dhoni built a culture of excellence by bridging the gap between the senior legends like Sachin Tendulkar, Anil Kumble and Rahul Dravid and a new generation led by Yuvraj, Suresh Raina and Virat Kohli. It was that unique combination of young and old with merit as the great unifier which saw India become the number one test Team in the world. Sadly, Rahul Gandhi was never able to create a similar enduring team spirit in the Congress party. The older generation Congressmen couldn’t fathom him, the younger ones didn’t feel empowered enough. Party loyalists may have accepted his leadership, but one sensed that they didn’t really respect him. It is a crucial difference. Respect, even in the sycophantic Congress culture, has to be earned—it isn’t conferred by birth.

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By the time the 2009 general elections arrived, Rahul Gandhi was established as a ‘national’ leader even though he still hadn’t proved his vote-catching abilities beyond Amethi. In 2004, Sonia Gandhi had dominated Congress posters. Now, she was sharing space with her son and the prime minister, Dr Manmohan Singh. In 2004, the Congress had almost given up on the elections. Now, five years later, there was a greater sense of self-belief. You could see it in the body language of Rahul as well. Where five years ago he had hesitated to step out of Amethi, he was now actively campaigning across the country. I managed to get a sound bite from him while he was on the campaign trail in Mumbai. ‘We’re winning this one, and winning well,’ he said with a cheery, dimpled smile.

He was right. The Congress won 206 seats, its best performance since its landslide win in 1984. Its UPA alliance won 262 seats which put it in a comfortable position to form a government once again. Manmohan Singh would be India’s prime minister once again, the first to complete two successive five-year terms since Jawaharlal Nehru. But the credit,